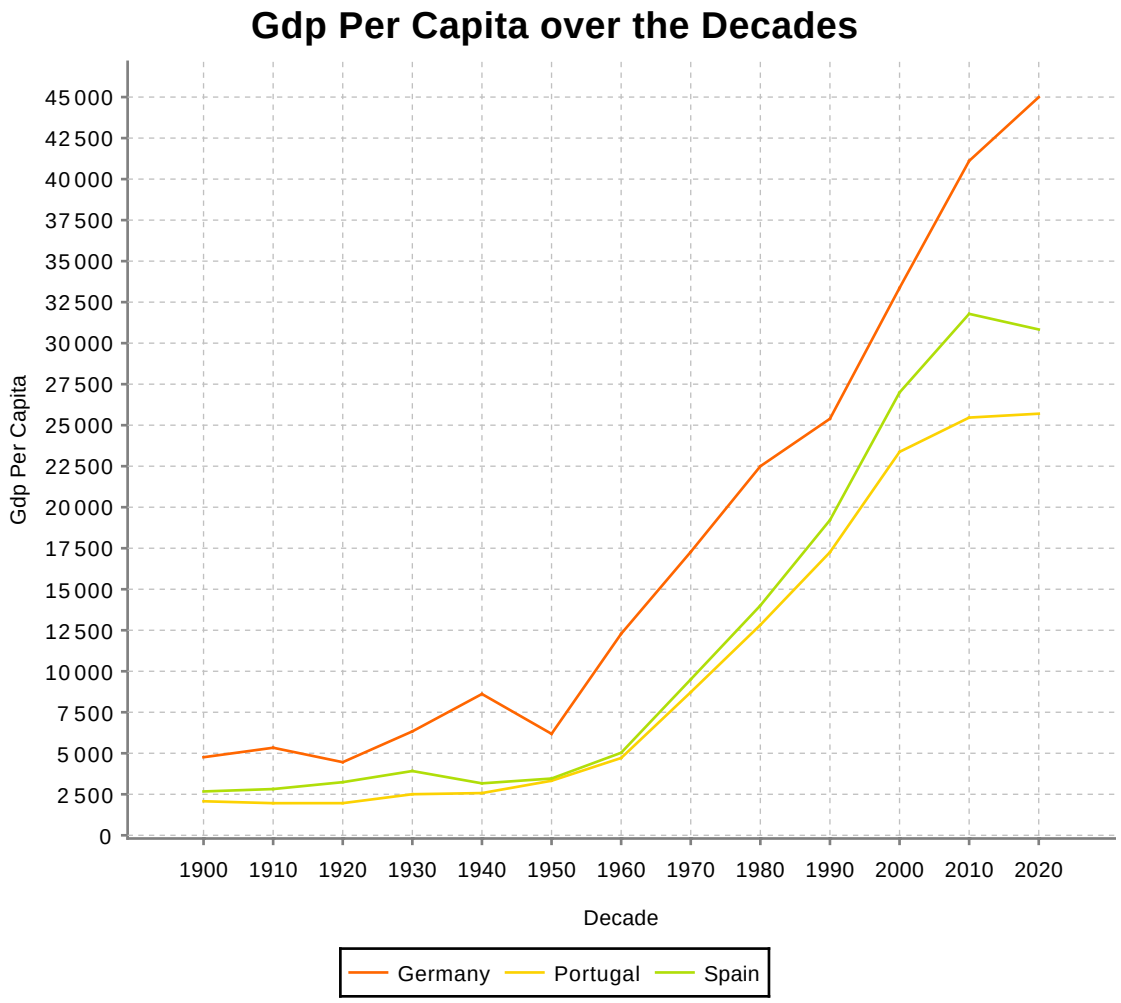
Portugal's Economic and Human Development: A Century of Transformation



Key events: Germany's early lead (1900-1945) reflects its status as Europe's industrial powerhouse, interrupted by two world wars and hyperinflation (1923), before the postwar Wirtschaftswunder (1950s) rebuilds its advantage. Portugal and Spain, by contrast, remain close together and far behind until the 1960s both overwhelmingly agrarian economies under authoritarian regimes (Estado Novo; Franco dictatorship). Spain's 1959 Stabilization Plan and Portugal's EFTA accession (1960) trigger parallel "economic boom" decades. Simultaneous 1986 EEC accession marks the steepest sustained convergence for both Iberian economies, narrowing the gap with Germany through the 1990s. All three diverge again after the 2008 financial crisis, most visibly Spain, whose housing bubble collapse (2008) and bank bailout (2012) produce a sharper dip than Portugal's own 2011 Troika bailout.

Portugal's Economic and Human Development: A Century of Transformation

Germany

Country	Life Expectancy	Year	GDP per Capita
Germany	NA	1900	4,758
Germany	NA	1910	5,337
Germany	NA	1920	4,457
Germany	NA	1930	6,333
Germany	NA	1940	8,612
Germany	NA	1950	6,186
Germany	69.1	1960	12,282
Germany	70.4	1970	17,277
Germany	72.8	1980	22,497
Germany	75.1	1990	25,391
Germany	77.9	2000	33,367.3

Portugal's Economic and Human Development: A Century of Transformation

Germany	80	2010	41,109.6
Germany	81	2020	44,996.4
		Average GDP per capita:	17,892.56

Portugal

Country	Life Expectancy	Year	GDP per Capita
Portugal	NA	1900	2,075
Portugal	NA	1910	1,957
Portugal	NA	1920	1,959
Portugal	NA	1930	2,504
Portugal	NA	1940	2,574
Portugal	NA	1950	3,325
Portugal	64	1960	4,712
Portugal	67.1	1970	8,724

Portugal's Economic and Human Development: A Century of Transformation

Portugal	71.2	1980	12,822
Portugal	74	1990	17,256
Portugal	76.3	2000	23,372
Portugal	79	2010	25,463.2
Portugal	81.3	2020	25,700.3

Average GDP per capita: 10,187.96

Spain

Country	Life Expectancy	Year	GDP per Capita
Spain	NA	1900	2,672.4
Spain	NA	1910	2,819.3
Spain	NA	1920	3,239.3
Spain	NA	1930	3,918.3
Spain	NA	1940	3,167

Portugal's Economic and Human Development: A Century of Transformation

Spain	NA	1950	3,459.4
Spain	69.1	1960	5,031.6
Spain	72	1970	9,502.9
Spain	75.3	1980	14,005.9
Spain	76.8	1990	19,215
Spain	79	2000	26,994.9
Spain	81.6	2010	31,786.4
Spain	82.2	2020	30,834.5

Average GDP per capita:	12,049.76